

FIRST ACROSS THE CHANNEL

IN THE LAST WEEK OF JULY 1909, two competitors, Hubert Latham and Louis Blériot, were waiting on the cliffs near Calais hoping to win fame, glory, and the *Daily Mail's* £1,000 (\$4,850) prize for being the first to cross the English Channel by airplane. On Saturday, July 24, the weather had been very rough, making flights look unlikely all weekend. The following morning, Blériot – who was suffering from a burned foot – woke very early and decided to drive to his hangar at Les Baraques. Then came a stroke of luck as the weather suddenly cleared. Blériot tested his engine, informed the French naval escort of his imminent departure, and waited for dawn.

Blériot was prepared for the cold: “I was dressed in a khaki jacket lined with wool for warmth over my tweed clothes... A close-fitting cap was fastened over my head and ears.” However,

SAFE LANDING

Blériot posing with his wife after crash-landing near Dover Castle. He crossed the Channel in just over 36 minutes, traveling at an average speed of 40mph (64kph).

his navigational preparations were far less meticulous. Visibility was poor, yet he had no compass, watch, or map.

At 4:35 am, Blériot rose into the air and flew off into the mist. The weather had been so gusty that Latham's friends assumed Blériot was just making a test flight, and when they saw the little monoplane

disappear out to sea they realized it was too late to catch him. Blériot soon overtook the French destroyer, but after 10 minutes found himself in a disturbing void: “I turn my head to see whether I am proceeding in the right direction. I am amazed. There is nothing to be seen –

neither the destroyer, nor France, nor England. I am alone; I can see nothing at all.” After a further 10 minutes struggling to keep his machine level, Blériot suddenly saw the English coast appear. He realized that he had drifted off his intended course and immediately changed direction. However, this brought him up against the wind

“A break in the coast appeared to my right, just before Dover Castle. I was madly happy... I rushed for it. I was above ground!”

LOUIS BLÉRIOT



DRAMATIC CROSSING

This image, taken from a cigarette card commemorating Blériot's famous crossing, conjures the drama of Blériot and his trusty steed battling through adverse conditions to victory.

and he battled his way toward the cliffs. Charles Fontaine, a reporter for the Paris newspaper *Le Matin*, was waiting for him just outside Dover Castle, and as Blériot emerged through the mist, Fontaine waved a French tricolour flag to guide him down. Caught by gusting winds as he crossed the cliffs, Blériot had some hairy moments before, as he put it, “I stop my motor, and instantly my machine falls straight upon the ground from a height of 20 meters [65ft].” It was not an elegant arrival – he had broken the propeller and smashed his undercarriage – but it was enough to enter the history books.

